INCIDENT REVIEW CULTURE

BLAMELESS POST-MORTEMS

When incidents happen, the goal is systemic learning — not punishment. A blameless culture means engineers report honestly, systemic causes get fixed, and failures don't repeat. Blame culture hides problems until they become catastrophic.

KEY BENEFITS

- ✓ Prevents repeat incidents by fixing root causes rather than symptoms
- ✓ Encourages honest reporting of near-misses — the most valuable safety signal
- ✓ Builds psychological safety that accelerates learning across the whole team
- ✓ Creates a documented knowledge base of failure modes and mitigations

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Google's SRE handbook mandates blameless post-mortems. Their core finding: incidents are almost always systemic — wrong incentives, missing tooling, unclear processes — not individual incompetence.

PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

A misconfigured deployment causes 40 minutes of downtime. The post-mortem produces three action items: add config validation to CI, create a deployment checklist, improve the rollback runbook. The engineer is not named in the report.

REFLECTION QUESTION

After your last incident, did the post-mortem result in systemic changes, or in someone being held accountable?